

Hyphens

HYPHENS ARE USED TO EITHER JOIN OR SEPARATE WORDS OR PARTS OF WORDS.

Sometimes two terms need to be shown to be connected, so that they are treated as one. Alternatively, a separation between terms may need to be emphasized. A hyphen can be used for both of these purposes.

SEE ALSO

◀ 26–27	Adjectives
◀ 56–57	Phrasal verbs
Numbers, dates, and time	118–119 ▶
Alphabetical order	128–129 ▶
Syllables	134–135 ▶
Roots	140–141 ▶
Prefixes and suffixes	142–143 ▶

Clarity

A hyphen is essential when the meaning of a phrase might be confused. When a hyphen is used between two or more words, it is a compound modifier indicating that the words work together to modify another word.

big-hair society

This hyphen indicates that the society is interested in big hair.



big hair society

Without the hyphen, the hair society is big.



The celebrated big-hair society
for a get-together about their



- **Compound modifiers** that contain adverbs **ending in -ly**, such as “extraordinarily hairy experience,” are **never hyphenated**.
- Names of **centuries** used as modifiers should be **hyphenated** before the noun, as in “twentieth-century issues.”
- A hyphen is used to **break a long word** in two **between two syllables** at the **end of a line**.

Verbs into nouns

When a phrasal verb is made into a noun, it is hyphenated. Phrasal verbs themselves are never hyphenated. For example, the phrasal verb *get together* in “Let’s get together and talk about it” isn’t hyphenated, but a hyphen is used when it becomes a noun: “for a get-together.”

a break-in

a get-together

a hang-up

an eye-opener

a write-up

a put-down